



Ground cover

US Army helicopters provide machine gun cover for South Vietnamese ground troops as they prepare to attack a Viet Cong base north of Tay Ninh, near the Cambodian border, in March 1965.

Airmobile limitations

Although helicopters allowed generals to insert troops quickly, and without the fatigue that a long march entailed, their noisy approach forewarned the enemy. Not only could the element of surprise be lost, but also the landing zone could be “hot”—under enemy fire. In addition, much of the terrain in Vietnam was steep and covered in jungle, making it difficult for helicopters to land, and even for ground troops already in place to create a landing zone of sufficient size. Although bombing sorties could open a patch of ground to create a landing zone, they could also telegraph an assault.

The airmobile units trained soldiers to rappel by ropes or ladders into dense vegetation that prevented aircraft from landing, but that maneuver also exposed the men to enemy fire. Despite these dangers, the suppressing fire from gunners in the Hueys and Cobras reduced the threat to the landing zone and to the helicopters themselves.

Airmobile tactics also had a strategic implication. The rapid insertion and extraction of troops was ideal for search-and-destroy operations in which US technology inflicted severe losses on the enemy quickly, but air mobility was less useful when it came to clear-and-hold tactics. It placed US units in remote places that were difficult to defend and sustain.